



Olympic cycle, several decisions were made that didn't align with Manu's training cycle. After the selection trials for the Olympics, the team was entered to compete at the Shooting World Cup in Munich, which wasn't part of her training plan at all. She eventually went but didn't compete. I believe going forward, shooters need to be trusted more to know what works for them.

Shooting can't be treated like hockey, where the team needs to train and compete together. Ultimately, the only one responsible for a shooter's success or failure is the shooter themselves," he says.

Rana insists his ideas are equally valid for any shooter bidding for a place in the Indian team for the Los Angeles Olympics.

Indeed, coaches feel that with nearly four years until the 2028 Games, there's no guarantee that the same shooters who competed in Châteauroux will be present in Los

Angeles.

"I think this makes this cycle a bit more challenging. The Olympic cycle for the Paris Games was much shorter than what we have now. There were just three years between the Tokyo Games and Paris. When we really look at it, even 2022 was a COVID-impacted year," says Deshpande. "This meant that last time, we mostly saw the same shooters who were part of the core group in Tokyo competing for the 2024 Olympics. I think, with the exception of Sift Kaur Samra (in the women's 50m three-position event), nearly everyone in the 2024 squad was on the edge of selection in 2021. The Olympic cycle really started in March 2022 for most shooters because only the core group trained continuously through the COVID years. We lost a batch of shooters due to that. Many were just starting to peak in 2023 and 2024, but because of the selection policy, their

Silver lining: India's Vivaan Kapoor celebrates after winning silver in the men's Trap final at the ISSF World Cup Final in New Delhi. PTI

scores came too late for inclusion in the Olympic selection trials. If the Olympics had been postponed by just six months, I'm sure we would have seen a very different set of shooters at the selection trials," she adds. "While that setback was significant, we didn't have to think too much about planning for 2024. There was almost no time for distraction because we had major competitions back-to-back. **This time around, it's very likely we will see a very different group of shooters in the squad for Los Angeles,**" she notes.

However, this situation comes with its own set of problems. "I think because we're going to have so many shooters pushing each other at the